

The ill-fated family, Jagdish Patel, wife Vaishaliben and their children Vihangi and Dharmik in an undated photo

THE BIG STORY | ILLEGAL IMMIGRANTS

GUJARAT'S SECRET HUMAN PIPELINE

Illegal immigration from Gujarat to the US is on the rise. **Hopefuls risk death, exploitation and human traffickers** to reach the promised land

By Kiran D. Tare in Gujarat

A 15-feet-high archway with murals of mounted warriors is a dead giveaway of the dominant community in Dingucha village in Gujarat's Gandhinagar district. The state's Patel community usually erects these structures to commemorate their warrior ancestors. The village, just 60 km from state capital Gandhinagar, has a population of around 3,500. Most of them live in double-storeyed concrete houses, with Royal Enfield bikes and Bolero SUVs parked outside. Several families from here have migrated to the United States over the past few years, but they haven't forgotten their roots. The village has a health centre, a high school and a grand three-storeyed Ram temple, all of them built from grants, or what sarpanch Madhurji Thakor calls "NRI money".